

Idioms & Phrasal Verbs

COMPLETE LEARNING GUIDE

What You'll Learn

Idioms and phrasal verbs are tested because their meaning cannot be derived from the individual words alone — a phrasal verb's meaning changes completely when its particle changes ('give up' vs 'give in' vs 'give away'), and idioms must be recognized as whole fixed units rather than parsed literally. The most reliable way to internalize both is through example sentences rather than isolated definitions, since the same idiom or phrasal verb can look deceptively similar to a related one with an entirely different meaning. This sub-module covers idioms as non-literal fixed units, how particle changes alter a phrasal verb's meaning, separable vs inseparable phrasal verbs, common confusions between similar-looking idioms, contextual selection in fill-in/replace-the-underlined-phrase questions, and a themed reference list for fast recall.

1. Idioms as Non-Literal Fixed Units

An idiom's meaning has nothing to do with the literal meaning of its individual words — it must be learned and recalled as one indivisible chunk, never parsed word by word.

- 'To let the cat out of the bag' = to accidentally reveal a secret. Example: 'He let the cat out of the bag about the surprise party by mentioning it in front of her.' (Nothing here literally involves a cat or a bag.)

2. How the Particle Changes a Phrasal Verb's Meaning

The same base verb combined with different particles (up, down, in, out, off, back) produces completely unrelated meanings — memorizing the verb alone is useless; the verb+particle combination must be learned as a unit.

- 'Give up' = to stop trying/quit ('He gave up on the project'). 'Give in' = to reluctantly agree/surrender ('She finally gave in to their demands'). 'Give away' = to reveal or donate ('His nervous laugh gave away the secret'). Same verb, three unrelated meanings.

3. Separable vs Inseparable Phrasal Verbs

Some phrasal verbs allow the object to be placed between the verb and particle (separable), while others require the object to follow the whole phrase intact (inseparable) — this affects which sentence constructions are grammatically valid, a detail placement tests occasionally probe directly.

- Separable: 'Turn off the light' or 'Turn the light off' are both correct (and 'Turn it off' with a pronoun object MUST split). Inseparable: 'Look after the children' is correct, but 'Look the children after' is not — 'look after' cannot be split.

4. Common Confusions Between Similar-Looking Idioms/Phrasals

Certain idioms and phrasal verbs look or sound alike but mean very different things — these near-pairs are frequent distractor material in MCQ options.

- 'Back out' (to withdraw from a prior commitment) vs 'Back up' (to support someone, or to reverse a vehicle/save data). 'By and large' (generally speaking) vs 'By and by' (eventually, after some time).

5. Contextual Selection in Replace-the-Phrase Questions

When asked to select the idiom/phrasal verb that best replaces an underlined phrase, first paraphrase the underlined phrase in plain words, then match that plain meaning to the closest idiom option — matching surface words between the underlined phrase and the option is an unreliable shortcut.

- Underlined phrase: 'He decided to postpone the meeting to a later date.' Correct replacement: 'put off' (= postpone). A tempting but wrong option, 'put down' (= to demean or suppress), shares the verb 'put' but means something entirely different.

6. Idioms of Agreement, Disagreement, and Effort

A cluster of idioms around agreement, conflict, and effort recurs constantly in business-English placement content — learning this cluster together, in sentences, builds faster recognition than scattered study.

- 'On the same page' = in agreement ('The whole team is on the same page about the launch date'). 'At loggerheads' = in strong disagreement ('The two managers were at loggerheads over the budget'). 'Go the extra mile' = to make extra effort beyond what's required ('She went the extra mile to finish the report early').

7. Building a Themed Reference List

Grouping idioms and phrasal verbs by theme (business, everyday conversation, time, conflict) rather than alphabetically makes them far easier to recall accurately when a question's context signals which theme is in play.

- Business theme: 'touch base' (make brief contact), 'run by' (get someone's opinion, as in 'run this by the manager'), 'iron out' (resolve minor problems, as in 'iron out the details').

Common Pitfalls

- Interpreting an idiom literally word-by-word instead of recalling its fixed figurative meaning as a whole unit.
- Assuming a phrasal verb's meaning is predictable from its base verb alone, ignoring how the particle changes everything ('give up' vs 'give in' vs 'give away').
- Confusing two similar-sounding idioms or phrasal verbs that share a word but mean unrelated things ('back out' vs 'back up').
- In replace-the-phrase questions, picking an option that shares a surface word with the underlined phrase rather than matching its actual paraphrased meaning.
- Not knowing whether a phrasal verb is separable or inseparable, leading to an ungrammatical reconstruction.
- Studying idioms as isolated definitions instead of in example sentences, making them harder to recall accurately under time pressure.

Key Takeaways

- Learn idioms as fixed figurative units — never interpret them literally.
- A phrasal verb's particle (up/down/in/out/off/away) changes its meaning entirely; memorize verb+particle as one unit.
- Know which phrasal verbs are separable (object can go mid-phrase) vs inseparable (object must follow intact).
- In replace-the-phrase questions, paraphrase the underlined text first, then match meaning — don't match surface words.
- Watch for near-identical idiom pairs that are frequent distractors ('back out' vs 'back up', 'by and large' vs 'by and by').
- Study idioms and phrasal verbs grouped by theme, in example sentences, for faster and more accurate recall.

Learn More

Cambridge Dictionary — Idioms

<https://dictionary.cambridge.org/us/dictionary/english/idioms>

GeeksforGeeks — Idioms and Phrases for Competitive Exams

<https://www.geeksforgeeks.org/idioms-and-phrases/>